

Relationship PIP.

A science-backed, goal-oriented reset plan for couples where one or both partners have avoidant attachment , built for measurable change, not just insight.

This is not a document about who's wrong. It is a structured agreement between two people who want things to work and are willing to be accountable to that goal. Your attachment styles are not character flaws; they are learned protection strategies. This plan names the patterns, sets concrete goals, and tracks real progress. When conversations go sideways, this document is what you return to.

PARTNER A (FA)

PARTNER B (DA)

DATE STARTED

FIRST REVIEW DATE

01 THE SCIENCE What Is Actually Happening in Your Brain

Understanding the mechanism before trying to fix it

□ Your attachment style is a survival strategy, not a personality flaw.

Attachment patterns form in childhood as the brain learns to answer one question: "How do I stay safe around people?" The neural pathways built then still fire today, automatically, before conscious thought kicks in. When your partner triggers that system, you're not overreacting. You're running an old program.

Bowlby (1969/1982) · Ainsworth et al. (1978) · Siegel, The Developing Mind (2012)

FEARFUL AVOIDANT (FA)

The Push-Pull

Negative model of self AND others

- Desires closeness, yet closeness also triggers fear
- Cycles between pursuit and withdrawal
- Emotionally floods quickly under conflict
- Fears both abandonment and engulfment
- Often hypervigilant to relational threat cues

DISMISSIVE AVOIDANT (DA)

The Fortress

Positive model of self, negative model of others

- Shuts down emotionally under pressure
- Withdraws to regulate, often without communicating
- Highly self-reliant, uncomfortable with dependency
- Minimises or dismisses partner's emotional needs
- Appears calm but is internally deactivated

90sec

The neurochemical wave of an emotional trigger (adrenaline and cortisol) cycles through the body in roughly 90 seconds. If the feeling persists after that, it's because your thoughts are re-triggering the cycle.

Jill Bolte Taylor, Ph.D., My Stroke of Insight (2008)

69%

Of recurring relationship conflict is "perpetual," rooted in fundamental personality and values differences. It doesn't get resolved. Healthy couples learn to manage it, not eliminate it.

Gottman & Silver, The Seven Principles for Making Marriage Work (1999)

⚡ Why the FA/DA pairing creates a self-reinforcing cycle

The FA partner's anxiety activates their pursuit behavior. That pursuit activates the DA partner's deactivation strategy, so they withdraw. The withdrawal triggers the FA's fear of abandonment, intensifying pursuit. The intensity triggers deeper DA shutdown. Both people end up feeling completely alone, for opposite reasons. This cycle is documented extensively in the Emotionally Focused Therapy literature.

Sue Johnson, Hold Me Tight (2008) · EFT research: Johnson et al. (1999)

ACTION: DO THIS NOW The 90-Second Body Check

- Each partner: place one hand on your chest. Notice your heart rate.
- Name one physical sensation in your body right now: not a story, just the sensation. Tight chest, shallow breath, knotted stomach.
- Say it out loud to your partner. No context needed. Just the body sensation.

This engages the prefrontal cortex and begins to regulate the amygdala's threat response, which is the neurological prerequisite for productive conversation.

02 What Sets Each Style Off

Know your triggers, and your partner's, before the next conflict

TRIGGER MAPPING

↳ Most arguments aren't about the topic on the surface. They're about the attachment threat underneath it. Identifying the actual trigger (not the presenting issue) is what breaks the cycle.

FA TRIGGERS

TRIGGER		LIKELY RESPONSE
Partner withdraws or goes cold	→	Panic, escalation, over-pursuit
Partner becomes too demanding	→	Sudden shutdown, pulling away
Criticism or perceived rejection	→	Shame spiral, attack or collapse
Feeling invisible or unheard	→	Emotional flooding, or dissociation
Unpredictability in the relationship	→	Anxiety spike, testing behaviors

DA TRIGGERS

TRIGGER		LIKELY RESPONSE
High emotional intensity or demands	→	Stonewalling, leaving the room
Feeling trapped or cornered	→	Complete shutdown, no response
Criticism or being managed	→	Contempt, dismissal, or exit
Partner's emotional dependency	→	Deactivation of intimacy entirely
Loss of personal space or autonomy	→	Withdrawal, avoidance of connection

THE LOOP: HOW YOU LOCK EACH OTHER IN



Nobody wins. Both people feel alone. The cycle repeats.

MY #1 TRIGGER (FA PARTNER)

What most reliably sends you into overdrive or shutdown?

MY #1 TRIGGER (DA PARTNER)

What most reliably makes you want to withdraw?

ACTION: DO THIS NOW The Trigger Swap

- Each person writes their #1 trigger on a piece of paper. One sentence.
- Swap them. Read your partner's without speaking for 10 seconds.
- Then say: "I didn't fully understand how much that affected you. Thank you for telling me."

No follow-up, no defence, no problem-solving. This step is acknowledgement only.

The 4-Step Connection Code

The only communication structure you need. Use it every time things get hard.

- ↳ Both partners commit to this structure. It removes blame and keeps the conversation goal-oriented rather than threat-oriented. It feels awkward at first. That passes. Screenshot this page.

1 SIGNAL: Ask First

Before raising something difficult, give your partner a heads up. Removes the ambush cue that sends DA partners to shutdown and hands them agency instead of threat.

"Hey, I want to talk about something. Is now okay, or can we find a moment in the next 24 hours?"

✓ Gives DA a moment to prepare

✗ Leading cold, when they're unready

2 SHARE: One Moment, One Feeling

One specific recent event, not a pattern or history. Pair it with one emotion. The more targeted the share, the less threat the DA partner registers, and the more likely they stay present.

"When you went quiet after dinner last night, I felt disconnected and unsure where we stood."

✓ "When [event], I felt [emotion]"

✗ "You always..." / "You never..."

3 REQUEST: Make It Concrete

Ask for something observable and measurable. If you can't tell whether it happened, it's a wish, not a request. Vague asks cannot be acted on and frustrate both partners.

"Next time you need space, could you text me saying you need an hour and you'll be back?"

✓ Specific + measurable + actionable

✗ "I just need you to care more."

4 RECEIVE: DA Partner, This Is Yours

Before responding, reflect back what you heard. The goal is not agreement; it's showing your partner their words landed. This addresses the attachment fear directly: "I am seen and heard."

"What I heard you say is [reflect]. I feel [honest response]. I can commit to [specific action]."

✓ Reflect first, then respond

✗ Defending before they feel heard

THE REDIRECT: WHEN IT GOES SIDWAYS

Either partner calls a redirect when: old grievances appear, blame enters, the topic has shifted twice, or neither can name the goal. It is not a shutdown; it is a return to purpose.

"I want to stay connected to what we were trying to resolve. Can we come back to [original issue]?"

Either partner can say this at any time. The other agrees to pause and return, even if it takes a short break first.

ACTION: PRACTICE ROUND

Run It on a Low-Stakes Issue

- FA partner: choose something minor and work through steps 1–3.
- DA partner: respond using the step 4 script. It will feel awkward. Do it anyway.
- Both say: "That was a good attempt." Growth is repetition, not perfection.

04 GOALS 30 / 60 / 90 Day Mission

Observable behavior, not emotional outcomes you cannot control

↳ **The PIP Rule:** Every goal must describe a visible, measurable action. "Be more open" doesn't qualify. "Stay in the conversation for 10 minutes before requesting a break" does. If you can't tell whether it happened, rewrite it. Goals are the anchor. When conversations drift into blame or history, return to these.

30 DAYS: FOUNDATION

DA PARTNER GOAL

FA PARTNER GOAL

Example: "When I need space, I will communicate that and give a timeframe before going quiet."

Example: "When I feel anxious, I will name the feeling out loud instead of escalating."

WEEKLY TRACKER W1 W2 W3 W4 Check each week it was met

60 DAYS: BUILDING

DA PARTNER GOAL

FA PARTNER GOAL

Example: "I will stay present in difficult conversations for at least 10 minutes before requesting a break."

Example: "When I notice I'm pursuing, I will pause, breathe, and ask myself what I actually need."

WEEKLY TRACKER W5 W6 W7 W8 Check each week it was met

90 DAYS: INTEGRATION

DA PARTNER GOAL

FA PARTNER GOAL

Example: "I will initiate one emotionally vulnerable conversation per week without being prompted."

Example: "I will trust and accept repair attempts instead of testing their sincerity."

WEEKLY TRACKER W9 W10 W11 W12 Check each week it was met

MONTHLY REVIEW: WHAT CHANGED?

GOAL	MET?	EVIDENCE / NOTES	ADJUST?
30-Day Goal	Yes / Partial / No		Yes / No
60-Day Goal	Yes / Partial / No		Yes / No
90-Day Goal	Yes / Partial / No		Yes / No

Weekly Check-In

15 minutes. Same time each week. Non-negotiable.

- ↳ Schedule this now, same day and time, recurring every week. Predictability is co-regulation for both attachment styles. Come prepared with honest answers. The goal is accuracy, not optimism. If the check-in starts drifting into an argument, stop and use the Redirect (page 4) to return to the questions on this page.

QUESTION	FA PARTNER	DA PARTNER
One moment I felt connected this week		
One moment I felt disconnected this week		
Did I use the 4-Step Code when it was hard?	Yes Partly No	Yes Partly No
One thing I want to do differently next week		
Overall connection this week (circle)	1 2 3 4 5	1 2 3 4 5

- ↳ End every check-in with this. It takes 60 seconds.
- Each partner names one specific thing they genuinely appreciated about the other this week. Make eye contact when you say it. The other person's only response is: "Thank you." No deflection, no minimising, no "but you also..." Receiving appreciation is a repair act. It builds emotional safety over time.
- Gottman, The Relationship Cure (2001) · The principle of "bidding and turning toward"

SCHEDULE THE NEXT CHECK-IN

DAY

TIME

LOCATION

Non-Negotiables and The Commitment

What each partner will not do, and what you both agree to

↳ These are protective limits, not punishments. Fill them in together, not at each other. Be specific. Vague limits like "don't be mean" cannot be enforced. Specific ones like "do not threaten to end the relationship during an argument" can.

Partner A (FA) Will Not:

☐ _____

☐ _____

☐ _____

Partner B (DA) Will Not:

☐ _____

☐ _____

☐ _____

IF A NON-NEGOTIABLE IS CROSSED, OUR AGREED NEXT STEP IS:

e.g. pause and reconnect in 2 hrs · contact a therapist · revisit this plan · call a trusted third party

The Commitment

We agree to use this framework as a tool, not as evidence against each other. When conversations go sideways, we redirect to the goals in this document rather than stay in the spiral. We commit to repairing faster than we rupture. We choose this relationship on purpose.

PARTNER A: FULL NAME

PARTNER B: FULL NAME

SIGNATURE

SIGNATURE

NEXT CHECK-IN SCHEDULED

EMERGENCY PROTOCOL: WHEN IT ALL GOES SIDeways

CALL A TIMEOUT

"I need 20 minutes. I'll come back and we'll finish this." Say it. Mean it. Actually come back.

REGULATE FIRST

Box breathing: inhale 4 counts → hold 4 → exhale 4 → hold 4. Repeat twice. Then return to the conversation.

THE REPAIR PHRASE

"That came out wrong. What I was actually trying to say was..." and that's enough. Clumsy repair still counts.

RECONNECT BEFORE RESOLVING

Physical proximity before problem-solving. Touch, sit close. Co-regulation precedes productive conversation.

Progress over perfection, every single time.

Attachment theory: Bowlby (1969), Ainsworth et al. (1978), Bartholomew & Horowitz (1991) · Gottman (1999) · Johnson (2008) · Porges (1994) · Bolte Taylor (2008)

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YOU MADE A COMMITMENT.

Now honor it, one week at a time.



Return to this document whenever you feel stuck, reactive, or lost. It is not a rulebook; it is a reminder of what you both said yes to.

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